

takes full-page ads in magazines and newspapers for the fund “with the best three-year record in its peer group.” Again, you’ve selected from a random sequence and come up with something that looks valuable.

Is There a Pattern?

Why do we fall for such tricks and listen to market forecasters who are no better than astrologers? Because the human mind is a pattern-seeking mind. We are all descended from people who are good pattern finders, because at some point our ancestors were walking around with some fellow hunters and there was a little rustle in the tall grass a hundred feet ahead. And Og said, “That’s the wind,” and Magog said, “I think it’s a leopard.” And Og marched forward and was leopard lunch. Your ancestor is Magog, who read that rustle aright. We’re all descended from people who were very good at finding patterns in things.

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All of us at some point in our lives lie down on our back on a hillside and look up at the sky and see objects or creatures in the clouds. At least, I hope everyone has done that. If you haven’t done it recently, you should borrow a six-year-old girl and go sit on a hill. It’s an excellent thing to do. And you will see patterns in the clouds—horses, whales, faces.

You’ll see them because we’re genetically trained to be pattern